

Burners Referee Guide

How the world pushes back. The players say what they do; this is the toolkit for everything they do it to — the passage of time, the dark closing in, and the first cold look of a stranger.

Three things run most of it: the Heat gauge you drive up and down as the scene's pressure, the Delve Die that decides what the dungeon does while the party spends time in it, and the Reaction roll that decides how the living things in it take to the crew. The two dice read on the same Sweet and Spicy grammar as everything else in Burners — you are pointing the familiar 2d6 at the world instead of at a character.

Running Heat

Heat is the crew's shared gauge and the spine of every scene — the full player rules are in [[Burners Adventure Game]]; here is how you drive it. It is the temperature of the room, not anyone's nerve: you narrate the room tightening and the number, face-up on the table, tracks it.

Open every scene at a base, set by how hot the room already is:

Base	The scene
3–4	Quiet — a meet, a market, an empty road
6	Working — the vault, the wilderness, the parley that matters
8	Loud — the job blown, the chase, the hall on fire

Feed it. Every shortfall the crew can't soak raises Heat by what they fell short — compress big misses, a botched sneak is +1 or +2, not +5. A blow past a defense, a blown roll, a hard parley all feed it, and you may raise it by fiat when fresh danger walks in (reinforcements, a lit lantern, the storm arriving), announced. Wounds do not feed Heat; they carry their own pressure.

Telegraph threats to set the room. Rough rubric: raise Heat toward the shown monster's **HD** — lower if the foe is disadvantaged, higher if it owns the situation. Reveal in stages and the gauge climbs with the fiction — spoor, then half-eaten kills, then the beast at full HD (a pack: summed HD, capped by chokepoints and the dark). Show the signs for slow dread; conceal them for an ambush that raises no Heat and strikes from surprise instead (the Delve Die's 1,1). Its presence sets the room; its attacks still quote its own Damage. Heat is the press dish — never the Monster Stack.

Work the valves. Heat falls when the crew acts on the room, not on request: fell or lose a named threat, -2; remove a named source (quench the fire, learn the ward-phrase), -1 or more; a Double Sweet vents 1; a steadying word or plan you buy, -1 once a scene. Folding ends the scene and cools to the next base. Downtime — a safe camp, a town between jobs — cools to base; a job that ended loud raises the base of what follows until the crew lies low and spends coin. Carousing is maintenance, not vice.

Heat joins the enemy side as its **Initiative / press pool** (preferred: **Heat dice only** — see [[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)]]). Climbing Heat makes them a little faster and lets them press quotes; it does not hand you a second PC-scale dice puzzle. Finish it or fold.

Running the Delve

The exploration turn is one World Turn — ten minutes. Each turn runs the same short loop:

1. **Declare.** The party sets a pace (cautious, normal, or hurried) and a primary action for the turn — move, search, listen, force, rest, interact, or something else.
2. **Present the Scene.** Frame the place in three strokes — Scene, Oddity, Risk (below). One vivid image, one thing that begs to be poked, one reason to hesitate.
3. **Resolve.** Play out the action: movement, searching, talk, a forced door, a fight.
4. **Advance the clock.** Add the Turn and roll the Delve Die. It is the one roll that used to be four — the wandering-monster check, the torch burning down, spells lapsing, the party wearing out — folded into a single pair of dice (see The Delve Die below). Update light, ongoing spells, conditions, and any clocks as its result dictates.

Roll the Delve Die once at the top of each Turn (see the frequency note at the end for running hotter or cooler). Between turns the loop just repeats: frame, resolve, advance.

Scene, Oddity, Risk

Every room, encounter, or travel scene should answer three questions. Build it in thirty seconds and it will run itself.

Scene — what do they immediately perceive? One or two sentences, no backstory: one memorable image and one dominant sense. The players should instantly know where they are.

Oddity — what invites investigation? More than something strange: something that begs to be touched, examined, talked to, experimented with, circumvented, or asked about. The players should think “what’s going on here?” If they can ignore it without a second thought, it is not a strong enough oddity.

Risk — what makes that investigation uncertain? Every interesting choice carries a possible cost: monsters, traps, hazards, time pressure, noise, resource drain, social fallout, a moral bind. The risk need not trigger at once, but it must be real. The players should think “how do we approach this?”

The test. If a scene has no curiosity, no meaningful interaction, and no consequence, it is just scenery — rewrite it. Run the checklist: can I picture it? do I want to investigate it? do I hesitate before I do? Three yeses and the scene is ready.

Example — Scene: a rope bridge spans a mist-filled chasm. Oddity: every rope has been cleanly cut, yet the bridge still hangs in the air. Risk: crossing or closely examining it wakes whatever holds it aloft.

The Delve Die

Roll 2d6 and add nothing — the dungeon has no Approach, it simply happens. Read the 1s and the 6s, not the sum.

- Any 1 shows → an encounter. Something has found the party. The other die is their lead time: how much warning they get before it matters.
- A 6 and no 1 → a break in the party’s favor.
- No 1 and no 6 → the grind. Nothing leaps out, but the dark still costs them.

When a 1 shows — the encounter and its distance

A 1 means something is coming. Its partner die tells you how close, running from *it has the drop on you* to *you have the drop on it*.

Roll	Lead time	At the table
1,1 (natural 2)	none	Surprise. It is on them before they know — they defend at the surprise penalty, one die only that first exchange (no melee yet to open unlimited Defend).
1,2	almost none	On top of them, knife-range. Roll initiative as normal, no time to prepare.
1,3	little	Close.
1,4	some	Nearby, both sides aware at once.
1,5	good	At a distance.
1,6	most	Distant. The party spots it first and holds the drop: avoid, hide, prepare, or turn ambusher.

The partner die is literally *how many beats away*. On the low end the monster has the initiative and the surprise; on the high end the party does. The far results double as the omen — a distant encounter the party detects first *is* the tracks, the sound, the light down the corridor, so you rarely need a separate “sign” result. Telegraph it as a Scene with its own Oddity and Risk.

When an encounter lands, roll the monster’s disposition on the Reaction table below, and build the creature per Building and Running Monsters (below). A thing with no capacity for parley does what its nature dictates and skips Reaction.

When a 6 shows and no 1 — a break

A good turn. A safe nook to catch a breath, a shortcut, a sign the party reads first, a glint of loot, a resource that holds. A double 6 (natural 12) is a real gift: a genuinely safe rest, a cache, a secret way, or the drop on whatever lies ahead.

When neither shows — the grind

No monster, no gift, but the dark is not free. One clock ticks — you choose which fits the fiction:

- **Light.** A torch gutters toward going out, a lantern’s oil drops a measure.
- **Supplies.** Rations, water, or ammunition run low.
- **Fatigue.** The grind feeds the crew’s Heat (see The Grind, below).

Pick the one that bites hardest right now. Deep in the dark with torches low, burn the light; on a long haul with everyone already frayed, feed the gauge.

The Grind — Light, Supplies, Fatigue

Fatigue is why the party cannot crawl forever, and it needs no separate clock — it feeds Heat, because Heat is the crew's shared wind and nerve, and wearing down a long crawl is exactly the loss of those. A fatigue tick raises the gauge, usually +1, and it rides there until the crew vents it.

A Journeyman keeps the band fresh. The [\[\[Burners Adventure Game|Journeyman's craft\]\]](#) reduces party-wide travel, weather, and survival costs by the Journeyman's Craft level, and fatigue in the dark is a survival cost like any other. Subtract the Journeyman's Craft from the tick for everyone they are leading: Craft 1 shrugs off a routine +1 entirely. Fatigue bites when the party has no Journeyman, when the Journeyman is down or split off from the group, or when the place is harsh enough to outrun their level. Scale the tick to the dungeon — a mild crawl adds 1, a brutal one (heat, thin air, crushing dark) adds 2 or 3, so a Journeyman's Craft matters more the worse the ground gets.

The over-extended party is the danger this builds: the grind pushes Heat up even when nothing is attacking, so a crew that lingers, lost and tired, walks into the next fight against a hotter scene — the enemy rolling a deeper pool and acting first. "We're worn thin and the room's boiling, and nothing's even swung at us yet — we have to get out" is the pressure a long crawl builds even when nobody has taken a wound.

Cooling off — and how HP comes back

Heat cools when the crew acts on the room (see [Running Heat](#)). HP and Wounds follow [\[\[Burners Adventure Game#Wounds\]\]](#):

- **Full HP closes wounds.**
- **Hour Rest** (one hour, food and water) fills HP to maximum **only if you have no Wound**.
- **Wounded: 1 HP per day** with food until full, then the Wound closes. *Vitae* / *Stanch* / potions can help; *Healing Touch* does not restore at 0 HP or less.
- **First aid** (Craft) tends a wound and can be the **help** for the post-fight survival check; it does not restore HP by itself.
- After a fight where you took a Wound: **help**, then **2d6 + Craft vs severity** — or die. Monster specials (spawn, etc.) if you die from that creature's attack.

Classic Crawl (optional campaign flavor): once unwounded and at 0+, use **1d3 HP per full day** in a safe haven instead of Hour Rest for luck recovery. Write the choice at session zero. Wounds and survival still run as above.

Fallen Wounds

Any of the Fallen that **wounds** you opens a **Fallen Wound**. Midnight / Purge: husks deepen by **1**; major / draining Fallen deepen by 1d6 + 1d6 per drain. Full procedure: [\[\[Burners Burn Undead#Fallen Wounds\]\]](#).

Reaction — First Impressions

Disposition is a fact of the world (see Influence in [\[\[Burners Adventure Game|the core rules\]\]](#)), and when it is not already fixed by the fiction you roll for it. Any NPC, monster, or faction the party meets fresh gets a Reaction: roll 2d6 and read the table. This is the world's own leaning at first contact — the roll only says how it starts; what you ask next is still the Two Steps.

Circumstances are the main lever. A drawn blade, a shared enemy, a debt, a standing feud, or a fearsome reputation shift the roll the way a situational modifier shifts a defend — set a plus or minus from the same bands. Where one character is plainly making the approach (the spokesperson, the one who speaks the tongue, the face of the band), add their Heart. And Sweet and Spicy ride along as always: a rolled 6 is a good twist on the meeting, a rolled 1 a complication, whatever the total.

2d6	Reaction	What it means
2 or less	Hostile	It moves against you now: attack, alarm, or bolt into a worse response. A natural 2 (fumble) is always Hostile.
3–5	Wary	Suspicion, hard words, steep terms. It would rather you were gone; push it and it turns.
6–8	Neutral	Uncertain and cautious, no commitment either way — the most open to being swayed by what you do next.
9–11	Amiable	Warm enough to talk, trade, or lend a hand, for a fair price or a good reason.
12 or more	Friendly	It takes a shine to you: real aid, a favor, the start of an ally. A natural 12 (perfect) is always Friendly.

Roll once at first meeting. Re-roll only when something material changes the footing: they save its life, they are caught in a lie, the faction hears what they did in the last town. A creature with no capacity for parley — mindless undead, a beast in a killing frenzy, a construct bound to its orders — skips the roll and does what its nature dictates; the table is for anything that can, in principle, be dealt with.

Reaction sets the starting disposition; the Two Steps and Influence carry the specific asks from there. A Friendly guard still will not hand you the keys to the vault, but he might look the other way where a Hostile one raises the cry.

Frequency — running hot or cool

Rolling the Delve Die every Turn runs a dungeon hot: any 1 lands about a third of Turns (of those, only one in eleven is the 1,1 surprise — most encounters are mid-range meets the party can fight or dodge), and a six-Turn camp will almost certainly stir something. That suits the Burners tone — in fast, out before the fog. If it runs too hot in play, roll every other Turn for the classic dungeon tempo, or treat the distant 1,5 and 1,6 results as a sighting the party can slip away from entirely rather than a committed encounter.

Building and Running Monsters

A monster is any enemy: Hit Dice, attacks, and a public **Monster Stack** of $2 \times \text{HD}$ playing cards (face-down closed / face-up open). Its Hit Dice are its level: most humans are 0, most orcs are 1, a veteran higher. How blows land on that stack: this section. Burner-side Fuel economy: [[Burners Principles#Pools, not fixed numbers]].

Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)

Monsters have Hit Dice. Deal each monster a **Monster Stack** of $2 \times \text{HD}$ playing cards. **Face-down** = **closed** (armored / shell). **Face-up** = **open** (meat). Ignore rank and suit. The stack replaces notepad HP. Players like a fat Fuel pool; you keep the enemy side **small and quotable**.

Pool = Heat only (one dish for the whole enemy side). Roll it for Initiative (count of 3s and 4s) and as optional Fuel when you **press**. Heat is not durability — never pluck it for damage. Set it from the shown threat: $\approx$ **HD**, down if the foe is on the back foot, up if it owns the fight.

Free attack (quote). Flat damage — no die from the pool.

Fiction	Quote
Light (dagger, claw d4)	2
Common (sword, claw d6, tentacle+cutlass)	2 or 3
Heavy (d8, axe, crab smash)	4
Huge (d10+, ogre, polearm-beast)	5

Paint (mix inside $2 \times \text{HD}$). Naked / sushi / tough hide with no kit $\rightarrow$ **all face-up**. Soft kit (leather, shield) $\rightarrow$ **some face-down** (orc HD 1 $\rightarrow$ **1 down / 1 up**). Mail/heavier $\rightarrow$ more face-down. True shell/plate/scales $\rightarrow$ **mostly or all face-down** (crab HD 3 $\rightarrow$ **6 face-down**). Soft armor **adds face-downs into the mix** — it does not invent a flat soak or a second track outside $2 \times \text{HD}$.

One blow:

1. Player announces **damage**. Keep the big number.
2. **Hits** = $\lceil \text{damage} \div 5 \rceil$ (always round up).
3. **Closed?** (any face-down remains, or flesh that shrugs their edge) $\rightarrow$ **-1 Hit**, always. Armor is one card of soak — -5 damage in effect. No spend waives it.
4. **Right tool** — the player claims it in fiction (“*I slice the sushi!*” / “*poleax on the shell!*”) and burns **one extra Fuel** into the blow (beyond the weapon’s usual dice); its face **adds** to damage before rounding. A deeper blow, not a waiver.
5. Pop **face-down first, then face-up**. **0** $\rightarrow$ bounce.

Damage	Hits	Closed (-1)	Open
1–5	1	0	1
6–10	2	1	2
11–15	3	2	3
16–20	4	3	4

Cracked! = last face-down gone — faces show; the armor -1 ends. **Dead** = stack empty; scoop.

Tactics: claim the right tool for the extra die when it matters — the player holds the story. Scraps after Cracked. A **1+2** is still 1 Hit (ceil); closed $\rightarrow$ bounce; the right tool’s extra die is how a stuck blow punches through.

Press (optional). Burn a Heat die onto a quote when it matters.

Hordes. Shared Heat dish. Attacks = bodies in reach. One **Monster Stack** ($2 \times \text{HD}$ cards) per body; soft kit only changes the face mix. Fat stacks for solos and named threats.

Shambling $\rightarrow$ act last.

Full-dice monsters (optional). Solo duel / demo as a Burner. Default is speed mode.

Also: experiments/burners-monster-stacks.md — Monster Stacks (and the older experiments/burners-cracked.md quote sheet).

Situational Damage Modifiers

The Referee raises or lowers Damage for the situation. Set a value from the band, or roll a swing die when the moment is chaotic. Narrate the cause so players can attack the reason.

Band	Feel	Examples
+1	slight edge	bad footing, downhill, a mild distraction
+2	clear advantage	from behind, flanked, foe in the dirt, grappled
+3	strong	surprised, blinded, struck mid-cast
+4	severe	pinned, ambushed in the dark, several stacked
+5	dire	helpless while the fight still rages

The defender's edge runs the same band the other way: partial cover is a 2, hard cover a 4, an attacker who is in the dirt or swinging blind gives you a 2 or 3. When a blow outruns the dice a defender can burn (a lone die, or as many as they like once they have meleed this round; two vs a missile with Cover) plus their armor, the excess lands on HP — and past 0 it cuts a score.

Swarms

Foes piling onto one target attack like a single Veteran of many levels: the group makes a bundle of attacks — reckon one per body in reach, or one per Hit Die for a larger creature — each its own blow of up to two dice, each defended separately, and each soaked by the defender's armor on the way in. Three orcs on Aldric are three attacks, not one big one. Once Aldric has meleed this round he Defends without limit against all of them; until then each blow is one die. An ally may **Block** for him (spend one melee attack to redirect one blow onto themselves). A chokepoint caps how many reach you at once; kill one and the bundle loses its attacks.

Keeping the blows separate is deliberate. A single combined Damage would blow past armor in one unsoakable spike; many small hits, each soaked on the way in, mean a mob wears you down through attrition and a draining Fuel pool instead — you run out of dice to defend before you run out of HP. That is the real danger of numbers: not one dreadful blow, but more attacks than you have dice to answer. The counter is avoidance — break line of sight, fight from a chokepoint, raise a shield as Cover, or thin the mob until the swings come slower than you can turn them.

Cover, Sparks, and shooting into the press

Fuel is rolled face-up. Everyone can see the 6s.

When a missile flies into a melee, the target may use a **melee foe as Cover** (see [[Burners Adventure Game]]). If they Fuel a Spark on that Defend, the shot hits that foe instead — often a Burner locked with them. That is the rule working as written, not a gotcha to spring cold.

Before the arrow goes: give a friendly warning. *“Are you sure you want to put that into the press? He's got a Spark sitting right there.”* The player still chooses. You telegraphed the risk while the dice were already on the table. See [[Burners Principles#No gotchas]].

The Safe Town

The party begins in a safe town, which is a haven but not a home base and not theirs. It offers lodging, food, supplies, law, healing, and rumors: a place to cool off, re-equip, mend wounds, and hear where trouble lies. The party are guests on someone else's ground, and the town has its own authorities and life. Adventures spiral out from it and back to it, and a party may later earn or build a true home base of their own.

Level here. XP banks in the field; characters spend it to gain a level only in civilization — this town, another haven, or a place where they can train and rest. Mid-delve rank-ups do not happen. Rare emergencies are your call.

Exploration crumbs (optional). A small XP award for a wilderness hex newly mapped or a dungeon room meaningfully explored rewards poking and mapping without replacing treasure. Tune the number; there is no fixed crumb.

Inventing spells and items. When a player wants a working or lasting item not in the catalog, treat it as a campaign project: time, rare materials, a teacher or ruin, and a clear failure mode. No price table. Arcana stay finds; research may yield a scroll or potion formula, or a one-off the table invents together. See [[Burners Sorcerie]].

Pricing Unlisted Gear

When an item is not on the [[Burners Equipment]] tables, price it from its slots and category, then adjust for quality and rarity and add it to the list. Listed gear uses the Equipment prices. The rates below are for **unlisted** pieces.

- Common gear (clothing, tools, a waterskin): 1 gp per slot.
- Fine steel and specialty goods (books, lockpicks, instruments, specialty tools): 10 gp per slot.
- Plain armaments (odd weapons not on the list): 5 gp per slot.
- Provisions: 1 gp per meal for the group.
- Ranged weapons and special materials such as silver add a surcharge when you invent a new piece.
- Arcana have no shop price — found, seized, gifted, or inherited. Scrolls and potions are downtime craft at $100 \text{ gp} \times \text{spell level}$ (see [[Burners Sorcerie]]).
- Heavy or exceptional armaments run far dearer: about 100 gp for a +1 grade, 1,000 gp for a rare +2 (added on a listed or formula price).
- Elevated quality adds to any item: +10 gp for fine, +100 for rich, +1,000 for noble work.
- Magic items are rarely for sale at any price; you decide whether one can be found at all. Stocking enchanted arms: [[Burners Referee Magic Items]].